I am saying to you that, when the moment comes, dare greatly. Don't be scared to dare and to risk it all. We have spent a long time together here at the World Cup, and we owe it to each other to promise each other that "with every broken bone" we're going to leave it out there tomorrow.'

My voice had almost faltered over the words 'risk it all', almost cracked with the emotion of everything going on inside my head, but I kept going and introduced the motivational film edited and produced by Andy Croly and Jared Hinde, the talented producer and videographer from the agency, T&W, who generally travelled with the squad and invariably found the images and music to move and inspire us.

I returned to my room and ordered room service with my wife, Danielle, but could not stop thinking about the selection issue. Russell sent me a text message, asking me to stay focused on the task, telling me how much the team needed my leadership; and Gary Kirsten also made contact, urging me to be calm and positive ahead of the big match. I needed to get my head around everything but I was emotional and, so far as I could see, the entire situation seemed so unnecessary and unfair on everybody.

I didn't sleep well that night and remember my first thought when I opened my eyes the following morning was 'I hope Vern will be OK'. I had met him when we were 13, got along well when we played together in the South African Under-19 side and had become good friends.

What's done is done, I told myself, let's go and play. I didn't want to overreact to what, at the end of the day, was just a perception. I didn't know for certain what had happened. Even today, I still don't know for certain what happened. I didn't want to blame anyone. I wanted to treat the issue as just another obstacle to be overcome. We had to deal with it.

Across the field, as we worked through our warm-up routines, the New Zealanders were planning to write their own story, playing in front of their own supporters, desperate to reach the Cricket World Cup final for the first time after they had lost all of their six previous semifinals.